

The Prelude

One summer evening (led by her) I found
A little boat tied to a willow tree
Within a rocky cove, its usual home.
Straight I unloosed her chain, and stepping in
Pushed from the shore. It was an act of stealth
And troubled pleasure, nor without the voice
Of mountain-echoes did my boat move on;
Leaving behind her still, on either side,
Small circles glittering idly in the moon,
Until they melted all into one track
Of sparkling light. But now, like one who rows,
Proud of his skill, to reach a chosen point
With an unswerving line, I fixed my view
Upon the summit of a craggy ridge,
The horizon's utmost boundary; far above
Was nothing but the stars and the grey sky.
She was an elfin pinnace; lustily
I dipped my oars into the silent lake,
And, as I rose upon the stroke, my boat
Went heaving through the water like a swan;
When, from behind that craggy steep till then
The horizon's bound, a huge peak, black and huge,
As if with voluntary power instinct,
Upreared its head. I struck and struck again,
And growing still in stature the grim shape
Towered up between me and the stars, and still,
For so it seemed, with purpose of its own
And measured motion like a living thing,
Strode after me. With trembling oars I turned,
And through the silent water stole my way
Back to the covert of the willow tree;
There in her mooring-place I left my bark, –
And through the meadows homeward went, in grave
And serious mood; but after I had seen
That spectacle, for many days, my brain
Worked with a dim and undetermined sense
Of unknown modes of being; o'er my thoughts
There hung a darkness, call it solitude
Or blank desertion. No familiar shapes
Remained, no pleasant images of trees,
Of sea or sky, no colours of green fields;
But huge and mighty forms, that do not live
Like living men, moved slowly through the mind
By day, and were a trouble to my dreams.

What actually happens in The Prelude

This anthology extract comes from **Book 1** of Wordsworth's long autobiographical poem *The Prelude*. The speaker remembers stealing a boat on a summer evening, rowing out confidently, then suddenly feeling dwarfed and pursued by a vast mountain. The experience does not end when he gets back to shore: it stays in his mind afterwards as "huge and mighty forms." *The Prelude* itself is an autobiographical poem in **blank verse**, first published **posthumously in 1850** after decades of revision.

Three ideas worth building everything around:

- confidence turns into fear
- nature is not passive scenery; it seems active and powerful
- the memory becomes a lasting mental experience, not just a one-off event

The method that matters most: the shift

The strongest thing to notice is the **turn** in the poem. It begins with secrecy and excitement — "an act of stealth / And troubled pleasure" — and the speaker feels smooth, graceful and in control, especially in "like a swan." Then the mountain arrives and the language changes abruptly into something darker and more overwhelming: "a huge peak, black and huge." That is the real hinge of the poem. The poem is built around a movement from pleasure to awe, and that is where the argument usually lives. The Romantic idea of the **sublime** is useful here: extreme natural experience can produce both fear and admiration at the same time.

"an act of stealth / And troubled pleasure"

Establishes the secretive, excited opening mood.

"like a swan"

The speaker at his most graceful and in control.

"a huge peak, black and huge"

The abrupt hinge — language darkens and overwhelms.

"with trembling oars"

Control has collapsed; fear takes over.

"huge and mighty forms"

The experience becomes psychological and lasting.

Language: what to zoom in on

The poem is full of movement words, but that movement changes value as the poem goes on. At first, the speaker seems elegant and controlled; later, nature takes over. The repeated adjective in "**black and huge**" is blunt and heavy, as if normal vocabulary has failed. The personification in "**with voluntary power instinct / Upreared its head**" makes the mountain seem alive and deliberate, which is why the moment feels so threatening. At the end, "**huge and mighty forms**" is much more abstract: the memory has stopped being just a mountain and become something psychological and haunting. The poem therefore moves from physical description to inward disturbance.

Wordsworth does not just describe the mountain as big; he makes it seem to act with intention, so nature feels superior to the human speaker.

1

Physical Description

Elegant movement words; the speaker in control

2

Nature Takes Over

Blunt, heavy language; personification makes the mountain deliberate

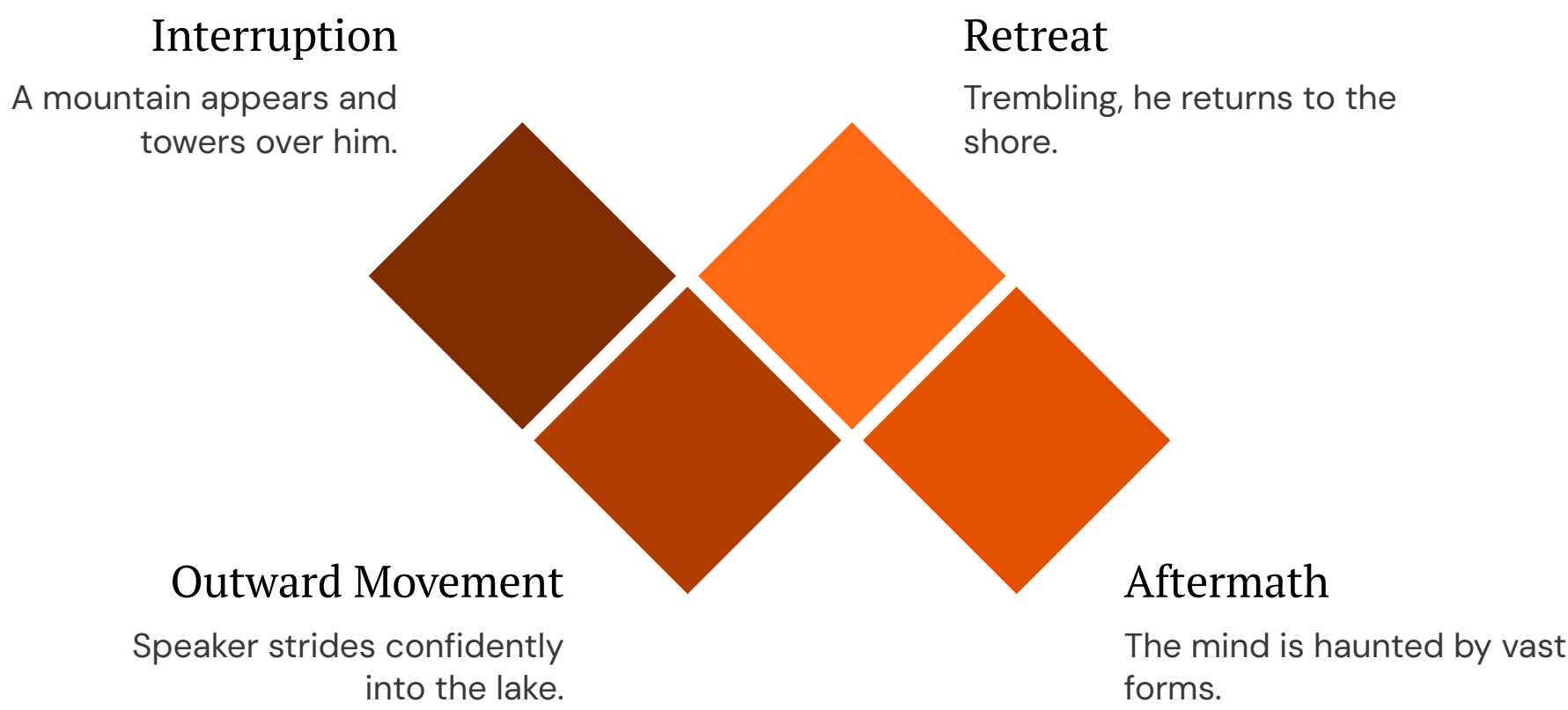
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Inward Disturbance

Abstract, psychological haunting; memory outlasts the event

Form and structure

This is an extract from a much longer autobiographical poem, and that matters because the voice is both immediate and reflective: the older speaker is looking back on the younger self. The poem is written in **blank verse**, which gives it a natural speaking rhythm rather than a tight, closed-off pattern. That suits a memory poem, especially one that feels like thought unfolding in real time. Structurally, it works as a clear sequence: outward movement, interruption, retreat, aftermath. The ending matters because the poem does not end with the boat trip; it ends with the mind still occupied by what it has seen.



The final lines widen from one event into lasting mental change — the real subject of the poem.

Worth naming in an essay:

Blank verse Natural speaking rhythm; suits thought unfolding in real time	First-person retrospective voice Older speaker looking back on the younger self
Central turning point The moment the mountain appears	Reflective ending Final lines widen from one event into lasting mental change

Context — and how to write it without bolting it on

Wordsworth is a first-generation **Romantic** poet, and Romantic writing is deeply tied to feeling, memory, imagination and nature. A key Romantic idea is the **sublime**: an experience of nature that inspires awe and fear at the same time. That fits this poem perfectly, because the mountain is not simply pretty or simply terrifying; it is both. *The Prelude* is also an autobiographical poem, so the focus is not just on the landscape itself but on how the speaker's mind is shaped by the experience.

Weak context

Wordsworth was a Romantic poet.

Stronger context

As a Romantic poet, Wordsworth treats nature as a force that can reshape the mind, which is why the mountain becomes a source of awe and fear rather than just scenery.

Another strong version

Because the extract comes from an autobiographical poem, the ending matters: the real subject is not only the boat trip, but how the memory continues to work on the speaker afterwards.

Likely question angles

These are the question types this poem lends itself to best:



The power of nature



Fear



The relationship between humans and nature



Loss of control



A moment of realization



Power and vulnerability

 Because this is a comparative anthology essay, the safest line is usually: **start from The Prelude's central shift, then compare the other poem through the same idea.** The exam section itself is one named poem printed on the paper plus one other poem from the chosen cluster.

Useful openings:

- Both poets present nature as a force that exceeds human control, but...
- While Wordsworth focuses on one transforming encounter, the other poet...
- The turning point in The Prelude matters because...

Best comparison: Storm on the Island

This is one of the cleanest comparisons because both poems are really about **human vulnerability in the face of nature**. In *The Prelude*, the encounter is personal and psychological: the speaker begins confidently and ends shaken. In *Storm on the Island*, the voice is collective — "**we are prepared**" — but that confidence is gradually undermined until the storm becomes "**a huge nothing that we fear**." Heaney was from **Northern Ireland**, and his work often grows out of rural life and landscape; the poem is also frequently read as carrying a political undertone because the language of threat can echo conflict and instability.

Useful links

- *The Prelude*: "a huge peak, black and huge"
- *Storm on the Island*: "we are prepared"
- *Storm on the Island*: "it is a huge nothing that we fear"

What to say

- Wordsworth makes nature feel suddenly personal and overwhelming.
- Heaney makes nature feel relentless, communal and inescapable.
- Both poems shift from confidence to fear.

Best comparison: Exposure

This works because both poems show nature overpowering humans, but they do it very differently. In *The Prelude*, nature terrifies one speaker in a single remembered moment. In *Exposure*, Owen turns nature into a long campaign of suffering: "**merciless iced east winds that knife us**." Owen wrote as a First World War soldier and produced most of his poetry in 1917–18, shortly before he was killed in action in 1918. In this poem, nature is not sublime in a Romantic sense; it is an enemy that wears men down.

The Prelude: "with trembling oars"

Fear is sudden, personal, and inward.

The Prelude: "huge and mighty forms"

The experience becomes reflective and psychological.

Exposure: "merciless iced east winds that knife us"

Nature is a relentless, physical enemy.

Exposure: "But nothing happens"

Fear becomes collective, repetitive and punishing.

What to say:

- Wordsworth's fear becomes inward and reflective.
- Owen's fear becomes collective, repetitive and physically punishing.
- Both poems strip human beings of control.

Best comparison: Ozymandias and Kamikaze

Ozymandias

Ozymandias works if the question is really about **power**. Shelley uses the ruined statue to show that human pride collapses before time and the natural world: "**Look on my Works, ye Mighty, and despair!**" ends up undercut by "**the lone and level sands stretch far away.**" Shelley's wider writing is strongly critical of oppressive institutions and authority, so the poem is a sharp attack on human arrogance.

Kamikaze

Kamikaze works if the question is about **nature's pull, a turning point, or a moment of realization**. Garland's pilot is stopped not by force but by what he sees below: "**little fishing boats / strung out like bunting**" on a "**green-blue translucent sea.**" Garland's own biography and commentary around her work connect her poetry with listening to other people's lives and with themes of life, death and the natural world.

Fast matching guide:

Power of nature

Storm on the Island / Exposure

Human pride versus larger forces

Ozymandias

A moment of realization caused by nature

Kamikaze

Fear and loss of control

Storm on the Island / Exposure